ONLINE STORE · VEHICLE WORKFLOW GUIDE (THIRD BRANCH OF THE SHARED MODEL)

Part 0

Start here: a website, explained to a Blender generalist

What a website actually is, how an online store is put together, where your Blender model goes in it, and how the interactive 3D landing page works. No web background assumed: every web idea is introduced through the Blender idea it resembles.

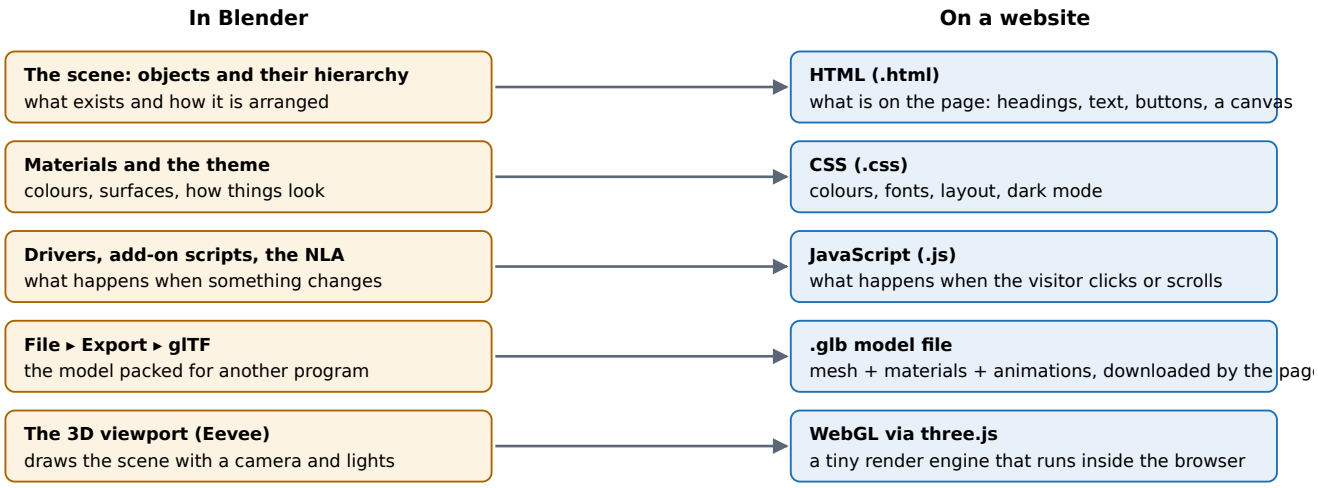
The store guide set

Part	Title	What you get from it
0	Start Here	The website in Blender terms, the whole store on one diagram, what you will and will not build yourself, glossary.
1	What a Store Actually Is	Catalogue, cart, payment, delivery, accounts, updates: the moving parts and who runs each one.
2	Site Map and Content	Every page, what goes on it, the product-page anatomy, the words, the legal footnote, demos and pre-orders.
3	From Blender to the Browser	The web GLB: poly diet, baking, textures, naming hotspots, NLA clips, export settings, size budgets.
4	The Interactive Viewer	How the demo viewer works line by line, explained as a Blender viewport: load, orbit, click, play.
5	Putting It on the Web	Hosting, domains, uploading, embedding the viewer in the storefront, mobile, speed.
6	Selling and Managing	Payments, delivery and updates, support, pre-orders and crowdfunding, legal names, taxes, a weekly routine.
7	The Branch Tooling	The Web Export Prep add-on, the demo site, how to extend both.

Sources: the “Texas Electric Railway: Payware Opportunity Analysis” conversation supplied with this project (store layout, product-page anatomy, pricing, legal naming, crowdfunding), the TSC and TF3 guide sets in this repository, and a working demo site (`store-demo/`) built and exercised for this guide. Claims demonstrated by that demo are marked **demo**; platform specifics you must confirm on the provider's own pages are marked **check**.

The website in Blender terms

A website is a folder of files on someone else's computer (a **server**) that a visitor's browser downloads and draws. That is the whole trick. Everything else is detail about which files, who hosts them and what happens when a button is pressed. The files map onto things you already know:



A page is a scene; a stylesheet is its material library; a script is its driver; the browser is the viewport.

Figure 0.1 · The analogy this whole set uses. You will not have to write much of the right-hand column: the demo site in Part 4 is complete and yours to re-skin, and the storefront (cart, payment, delivery) is rented from a provider, not built.

The whole store on one diagram

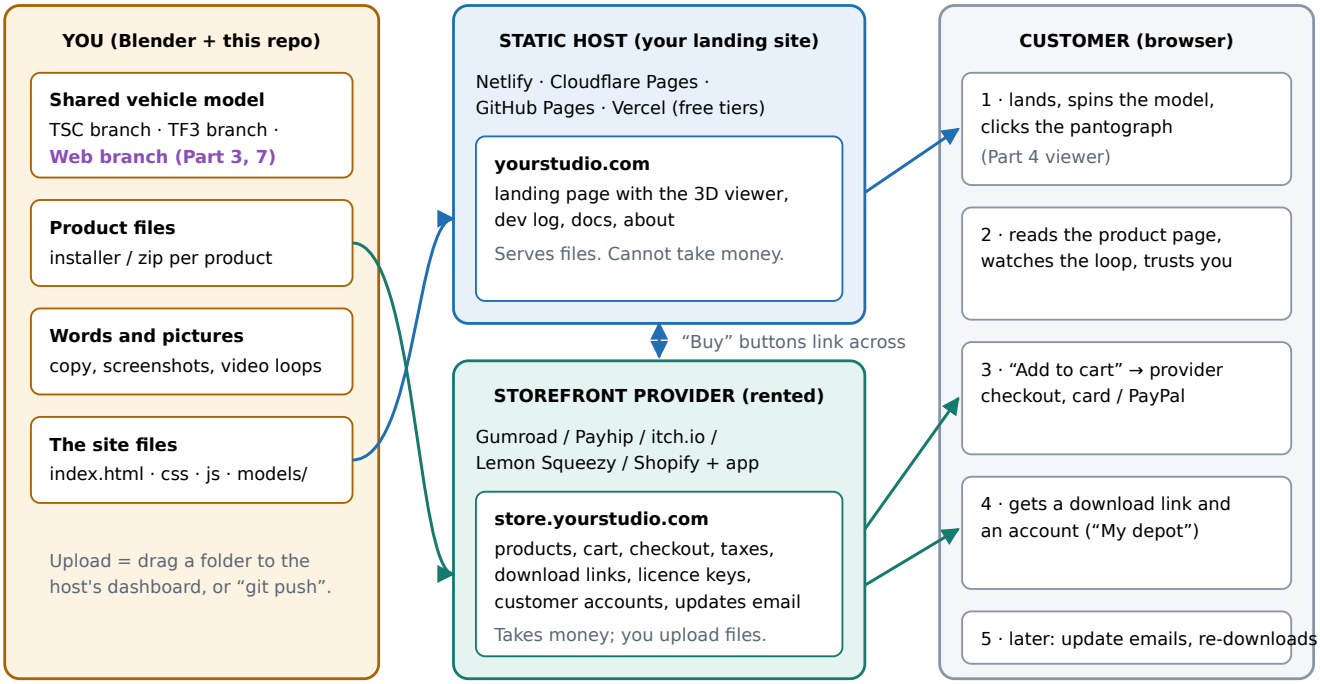


Figure 0.2 · Two halves, one brand. The landing site is files you make and host for free; the storefront is a service you rent that handles money and delivery. They are joined by links and a shared look. This split is what lets a non-developer run a professional store: you never touch payments code.

What you will build, rent and skip

Piece	Who does it	Notes
Vehicle models, animations	You (Blender)	Already done for the games; the web branch re-exports them (Part 3).
Interactive viewer	Done for you	`store-demo/` is a complete landing page; re-skin colours and swap in your models. **demo**
Landing site pages	You, with templates	Edit text in HTML like editing a document; Part 2 gives the content, Part 5 the upload.
Cart, checkout, taxes, delivery, accounts	Rented	Gumroad/Payhip/Lemon Squeezy/Shopify do all of it for 3–10%. Never build this. **check** current fees.
Payments (Stripe/PayPal)	Inside the rented store	You connect a bank account once.
Installers / zips	You	One per product, uploaded to the store; versioned (Part 6).
Marketing loops, screenshots	You (Blender/Game)	Captured from the sim; video loops are the landing-page background.
Forum, Discord, mailing list	Rented/free	Links from the site; the provider sends purchase and update emails.

Conventions and a glossary

Term	Meaning (and the Blender idea it resembles)
Browser	Chrome, Firefox, Safari, Edge: the program that downloads and draws pages. Think “the viewport plus a file loader”.
Server / host	A computer that keeps your files online. “Static host” = only files, no logic; that is all the landing site needs.
Domain	The name people type (yourstudio.com). Rented yearly; pointed at your host and your store.
HTML / CSS / JS	Content / look / behaviour. See Figure 0.1.
glTF / .glb	The web's 3D file format; .glb is the single-file binary version. Blender exports it natively.
three.js	A JavaScript library that renders 3D in the browser (WebGL). The viewer uses it. It is the “render engine”.
WebGL / WebGPU	The browser's graphics API. Every modern browser, phone included, has WebGL.
CDN	Content delivery network: a public host for libraries and big files. “Linked library” in Blender terms.
Raycast	Finding what is under the mouse. The viewer does what Blender does when you click an object in the viewport.
Manifest	A small JSON text file the viewer reads: which model, which parts are clickable, which animation each plays. Written by the add-on.
Storefront provider	Gumroad, Payhip, Lemon Squeezy, itch.io, Shopify…: the rented half (Figure 0.2).
Checkout / gateway	The payment page and the company moving the money (Stripe, PayPal). Inside the provider.
Digital delivery	The provider's time-limited download link and the customer's account library.
Licence key	A code the provider generates per sale; optional, used if your installer checks it.
Pre-order / greenlight	Selling before shipping; the funding model from the opportunity analysis (Part 6).
demo	Shown working in `store-demo/` (headless browser test, screenshots in Part 4).
check	Provider fees, limits and menus change; confirm on their site.

How to use this set

Read Parts 1 and 2 to decide what the store is. Then do Part 3 with one real vehicle: when your own model spins in the demo viewer on your own machine (double-click `store-demo/index.html` through a local server as Part 5 shows), the rest is uploading and writing. Keep Part 6 as the operating manual once sales start.